פרשת בראשית, a new cycle for the year. The holy Yid of P'shischa was known to have great insight in the important things in life. One of the דברי מוסר that he had was that he advised people to always wear a jacket with pockets on both sides. He said that in the two pockets, he should have two different slips of paper. On one side he should have a piece of paper that says בשבילי נברא העולם. In the other pocket, he should have the phrase, אנכי עפר ואפר. I found an interesting parallel in פרשת בראשית.

Regarding שבת the pasuk says (2:2), וַיְכַל אֱלֹקִים בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה וַיִּשְׁבֹּת בַּיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי מִכָּל מְלַאכְתּוֹ אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה - הקדוש ברוך הוא completed his work on יום השביעי, and he rested on יום השביעי. The question is that there's a מיניה וביה סתירה in the pasuk. It says that Hashem finished his work, and in the same pasuk it says וַיִּשְׁבֹּת - he rested from his work. Did Hashem work or did He rest? The answer that's always given is, and I'll quote it now verbatim from בראשית רבה (י׳:ט׳): הוּא בָּשָׂר וָדָם שֶׁאֵינוֹ יוֹדֵעַ לֹא עִתָּיו וְלֹא רְגָעָיו וְלֹא שְׁעוֹתָיו - Since we cannot determine the precise moment when שבת comes in, we have to perforce add on from חול to קודש; אֲבָל הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא שֶׁהוּא יוֹדֵעַ רְגָעָיו וְעִתָּיו וּשְׁעוֹתָיו, נִכְנַס בּוֹ כְּחוּט הַשַּׁעֲרָה הקדוש ברוך הוא knows precisely the way that time is running, Hashem created time, and therefore He knows exactly when שבת starts and when שבת ends. This בראשית רבה appears to be pointing out man's deficiencies, man's limited view of the world, man's inability to be as precise as כביכול הקדוש ברוך הוא.

The גאון וילנא changes the meaning of this בראשית רבה just a drop. To repeat: בָּשָׂר וָדָם שֶׁאֵינוֹ יוֹדֵעַ לֹא עִתָּיו וְלֹא רְגָעָיו וְלֹא שְׁעוֹתָיו - A man does not know his moments, his minutes, or his hours. The מדרש is telling us we have no control over our lives; we don't know how long our lives will last. We have no control at all over one of the most basic aspects of life, which is time. That is man's limitation. Look how little we are, look how imprecise we are, look how humble we should be because of this fact of knowing so little about even every moment of the day. That's what the מדרש is telling us. When שבת comes in, we should glorify and magnify הקדוש ברוך הוא's greatness as מלך מלכי המלכים, especially when *we* look at it from the point of view that we are unable to do that at all. So, אנכי עפר ואפר, the famous saying about עפר ואפר: עפר is dirt, it has no past. אפר is ashes, has no future. אברהם אבינו was saying, I have no past and no future. I am nothing. Therefore, if we recognize our humility and our true station in life, we will be better people.

Let's go to another pasuk. The pasuk says when הקדוש ברוך הוא was preparing to create אדם הראשון, he had a conference with the מלאכים. He said (1:26), נַעֲשֶׂה אָדָם בְּצַלְמֵנוּ כִּדְמוּתֵנוּ וְיִרְדּוּ בִּדְגַת הַיָּם וּבְעוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם וּבַבְּהֵמָה וּבְכָל הָאָרֶץ וּבְכָל הָרֶמֶשׂ הָרֹמֵשׂ עַל הָאָרֶץ. In מסכת ברכות (ס׳ ע״ב) this pasuk is brought down with the following rather startling observation: כְּשֶׁאָדָם קוֹשֵׁר שְׂרוֹכֵי נְעָלָיו בַּבֹּקֶר, מַה הוּא אוֹמֵר? ״בָּרוּךְ שֶׁעָשָׂה לִי כָּל צָרְכִּי״ - when a person ties his shoes in the morning; לֵימָא: כִּי סַיֵּים מְסָאנֵיהּ - Hashem, you have made for me all that I need. The גאון וילנא again asks, what do all of the things that we need have to do with putting on our shoes? Is the fact that we put on our shoes fulfilling all of our requests and our needs?

The גאון answers with the famous pasuk in תהלים (8:7): תַּמְשִׁילֵהוּ בְּמַעֲשֵׂי יָדֶיךָ כֹּל שַׁתָּה תַחַת רַגְלָיו - Everything that is in creation is under man's dominion. The pasuk tells you that we have a שליטה. הקדוש ברוך הוא gave Man the power to control the entire בריאה. We take a seed, we can crush it up, make it into food, or we can plant it and we can make it into many plants which we can eat or feed them to our בהמות. We can take the בהמה and we can שחט it. We can use the בהמה as food. We can use the בהמה as a source of milk. We can use the leather of the בהמה to make a shoe. Hashem gave us these opportunities to control the world. Man's purpose is to be שולט in the world for one reason and one reason only: because הקדוש ברוך הוא said so. הקדוש ברוך הוא says, you rule the world, we have to do that job as part of our responsibility that Hashem gives us.

The גאון וילנא has an amazing insight that he quotes from the sefer אמרי נועם. Why do we say שֶׁעָשָׂה לִי כָּל צָרְכִּי in לשון עבר, שֶׁעָשָׂה לִי? Because this ממשלה, this rulership of the world, we already got this from מעשה בראשית. That's what the פרשה is telling us.



https://youtu.be/Nfk06WsVAyI

בשבילי נברא העולם. On the one hand, yes, אנכי עפר ואפר. But Hashem also told us that we rule the world. If we rule it properly, Hashem will let us continue ruling the world. It is our job, our function, in exactly the same way as it is our job to remain humble as we do it. Let's try to work on both of these things and see if we can pull it off. Not an easy task, but it's doable only because the Torah says so.

https://youtu.be/Nfk06WsVAyI